The admin that costs money: assistive technology for adults with ADHD and learning disabilities

There is almost always an envelope somewhere in my house that I have not opened. I know roughly what it is. I know it is not urgent, because the urgent ones look different. Opening it would take about forty seconds. Nothing about the task is difficult, which is the part people find hardest to accept.

Most writing about learning disabilities and attention deficit disorder is about school. Reading levels, classroom accommodations, getting a child through an exam. That work matters. Much less gets written about what happens afterwards, when the same difficulties stop affecting homework and start affecting renewals, bills, forms and letters from organisations that charge you for being late.

I am ADHD and autistic rather than dyslexic, so I will leave the specifics of decoding text to the people who live that. The part I can speak to is executive function, and the paperwork problem belongs to both groups.

Why life admin is harder than the task looks

Admin has an unusual combination of features, and almost every one of them works against a brain with executive function difficulties.

There is no deadline you can feel. A letter sits at the same level of urgency on day one and day twenty, right up until the moment it becomes expensive. Nothing about the envelope changes to tell you which day you are on.

The language is dense. Letters from utilities, insurers, lenders and benefits offices are written in the least readable register available, and they bury the one sentence that requires action somewhere in the third paragraph.

Most admin tasks need information you do not have in front of you. An account number, a reference, a policy date, a password you set up four years ago. So the task is not really one task. It is a task with a lookup attached, and the lookup is where it stalls.

And it is boring. For ADHD in particular, interest is not a luxury that makes work more pleasant. It is part of the machinery that gets work started at all.

Each of those frictions is small. Executive function is what you would normally use to push through something small and tedious, and that is precisely the resource in short supply.

What unopened paperwork actually costs

This is the part that gets discussed least, and it is worth being plain about.

Late fees arrive on bills you could easily have paid. The money was in the account. The letter was on the table. Insurance renews automatically at a worse rate than you would have found in ten minutes of looking, because the reminder came in a letter you did not

open. Subscriptions continue for months past the point of usefulness, because cancelling requires a phone call rather than a click. Documents get replaced at a cost because nobody can find the original. Entitlements expire quietly: a reduced fee you qualified for, a deadline to appeal something, a window to switch.

Interest and charges compound, so a thing that was free to do in week one costs money by week six.

None of that is careless spending. People in this position are frequently careful with money, sometimes anxiously so, and still lose it this way.

> *The money is rarely lost in the decision. It is lost in the gap between deciding and doing.*

That distinction changes which tools help. Budgeting advice assumes the problem is the decision. The problem is the gap.

Text to speech turns a reading wall into a listening task

The most useful thing I have found for dense post is not reading it at all.

Speak Screen on an iPhone or iPad will read whatever is on screen. Microsoft Edge has Read Aloud built in, and Immersive Reader in Word will read a document while highlighting the line, which helps if your eyes slide off text. LDRFA has a fuller round-up of text to speech tools than I could give here.

The specific trick for admin is to listen while your hands are busy. Washing up, walking, tidying. A letter that feels impossible to sit down and read is often fine as something playing in the background, because the activation cost of listening is far lower than the activation cost of sitting down to concentrate.

Photograph the paper, then let your phone read it

Paper is worse than email, because paper cannot be searched.

Live Text on an iPhone lets you point the camera at a letter, select the text straight off the page, and copy it or have it read out. Google Lens does the same on Android. Apple lists the current features on its accessibility pages.

The immediate benefit is not having to read the letter. The larger benefit arrives later: a photographed letter sitting in your camera roll is findable by its own text. Searching your photos for an account number and getting the letter back is a genuinely different experience from going through a drawer.

If writing is the harder direction for you, speech to text tools cover the same ground in reverse, which matters for forms and complaint letters.

Reminders that fire at the moment you can act

Most reminders fail for the same reason. They name the goal rather than the next physical action, and they arrive when you cannot do anything about it.

"Renew car insurance" at nine in the morning on a workday will be dismissed. "Ring 0800 number, policy 4471, renewal quote" at seven in the evening has a chance, because it arrives when you are free and it carries the lookup inside it. Putting the reference number in the body of the reminder removes the step where the task usually dies.

Voice assistants earn their place here, not for anything clever, but because the cost of capture is almost nothing. Saying a reminder out loud the second you think of it beats any system that requires you to open an app first. LDRFA has a comparison of the main voice assistants for exactly this sort of use.

Automate the recurring payments before anything else

This is the least interesting suggestion here and comfortably the most effective.

Anything fixed and recurring should leave your account without you touching it. Direct debit, autopay, standing order, whatever your bank calls it. One setup session removes an entire category of late fee permanently, which no amount of remembering will match.

Two honest caveats. Only automate amounts you can reliably cover, and keep a buffer in the account, because autopay against an empty balance swaps a late fee for an overdraft charge. And check the statements occasionally, since automation is also how forgotten subscriptions survive for years.

One place where everything lands

A physical tray by the door, and one folder on your phone. Everything goes there, unopened if necessary.

The purpose is not tidiness. It removes the search step. When paperwork is distributed across a kitchen counter, a car, a coat pocket and three email accounts, every task begins with a hunt, and the hunt is usually what ends it.

The part that is not about systems

Tools reduce friction. They do not touch the other reason envelopes stay shut, which is that opening one means looking at evidence that you failed at something simple, again.

That feeling responds badly to better software and quite well to being named. Nothing about the difficulty of starting a boring task reflects your intelligence, your effort or how much you care about the outcome. Plenty of people who struggle with it hold down demanding work. The gap between what you can do when engaged and what you can do when bored is wide, and it is a feature of the condition rather than a verdict on you.

The practical version of this is to take the decision out of your hands. Open the post at a fixed time, or with someone else in the room. A habit or another person will carry you past the bit where willpower runs out.

That envelope does get opened. These days it gets opened because a reminder goes off at a time when I am free, and the reminder has the account number sitting in it. That is a less satisfying answer than discipline, and it works more reliably.

Author bio

J.M. Struijk is an autistic writer with ADHD, originally diagnosed with Asperger's, and a single father who raised a child with autism and ADHD. His books are practical and non-clinical, written for adults working out what a late diagnosis means day to day. Free tools, including an ADHD Tax Calculator and a Subscription Audit, are at jmstruijk.com.